History

2026-03-23

Contents

History **2**

1. Purpose and Question of the Investigation 2
2. Method of Investigation 2
3. Overview of the Model 3
4. Results: Overall Picture 3
5. Results: Examination of Major Theories 5
6. Cross-Domain Patterns 9
7. Unresolved Questions 9
8. Conclusion 10

History

1. Purpose and Question of the Investigation

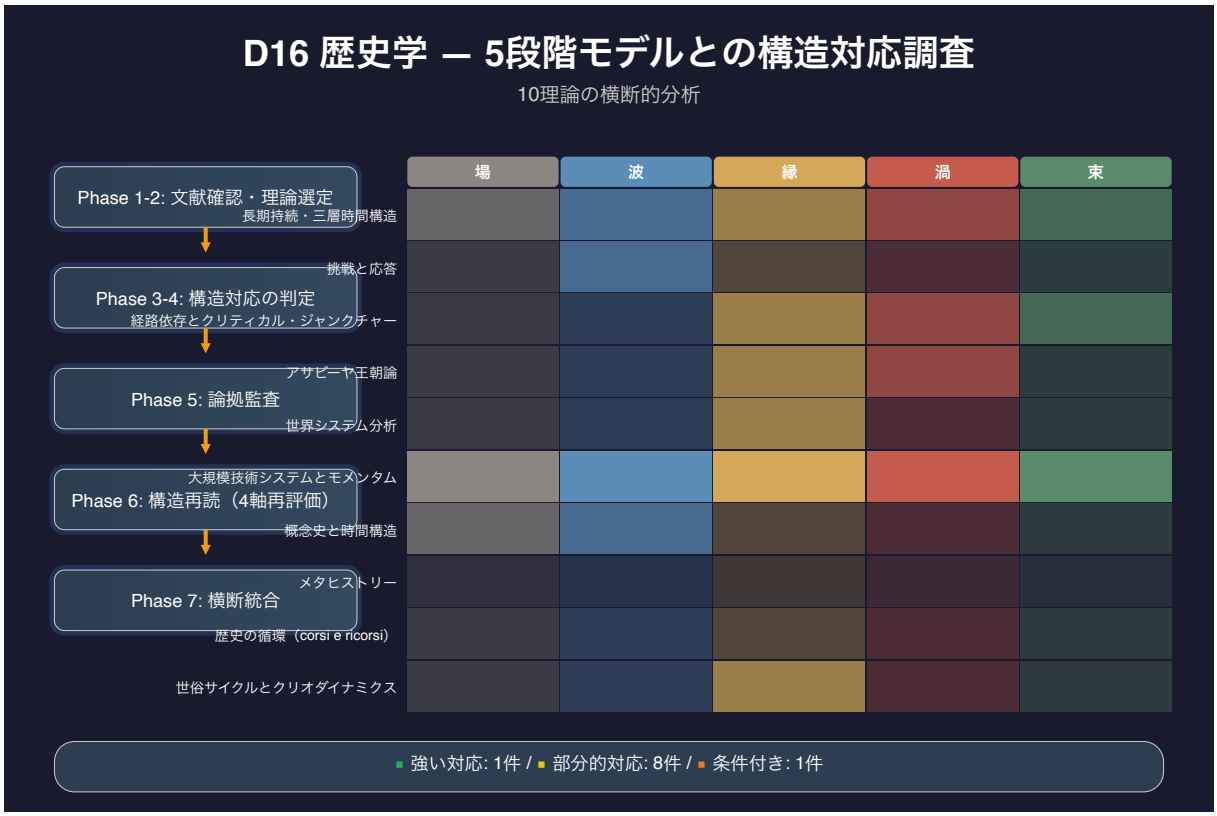

Figure 1: History —

This report was prepared to answer the following question.

> Do the theories of this academic domain correspond structurally to the five-stage model, Field -> Wave -> Edge -> Vortex -> Bundle?

History is a discipline that describes processes of change, and it is a domain in which structural correspondence with the five stages can be found from multiple angles. Cycles, spirals, multiple temporal layers, and path dependence all make historical change itself a field for testing the scope of the five-stage model.

This document is a report of findings. It is not a document intended to justify any particular theory. Places where correspondence is strong and places where reservation remains are described with the same level of restraint.

2. Method of Investigation

Objects and Selection Criteria

Ten theories or practical models were evaluated in this domain. Selection was guided by three criteria: (1) the theory explicitly treats processes of generation or transformation; (2) structural analysis is possible on the basis of primary texts or well-established secondary literature; and (3) the set allows comparison across distinct lineages within the field.

Method of Evaluation

For each theory, the investigation first clarifies what the theory is describing and then examines where correspondence with the five stages may be found. Judgments were made on the basis of textual concepts, concrete examples, connection between stages, presence or absence of circulation from Bundle to the next Field, and the risk of forced interpretation.

Criteria of Judgment

- **Strong structural correspondence**: The core concepts of the theory correspond concretely to multiple stages of the five-stage model, and the body of the report can explain why.
- **Conditional correspondence**: Correspondence can be indicated, but interpretive reservation remains in the stage mapping.
- **No correspondence confirmed**: Partial resemblance is present, but the theory cannot be read naturally as a five-stage structure as a whole.

Limits of the Investigation

This investigation does not examine every work by each theorist exhaustively. It focuses on the central concepts of major works and extracts structure at a level fine enough for comparison. As a result, some detail internal to the theories and some disagreements in the history of interpretation remain outside the present scope.

3. Overview of the Model

The five-stage model describes creative process through the following five stages.

Stage	Definition
Field	An undifferentiated state, an initial condition in which neither direction nor structure has yet been fixed
Wave	A stage of exploration in which multiple directions diverge and difference is amplified
Edge	A stage of tension in which opposing elements coexist without immediately converging into one side
Vortex	A stage in which a new coherence or order rises out of the tension
Bundle	A stage in which form is fixed and stabilizes as a reusable structure

This model is not a one-way straight line. It includes circulation in which Bundle becomes the condition for the next Field. The five stages are also better understood as a continuous spectrum than as rigid boxes. The model includes the hypothesis that the same structure may recur at different scales, from momentary thought to institution-building and long historical change.

If discomfort remains at this point, that is itself an important part of the investigation. Readers can continue while holding onto that discomfort.

4. Results: Overall Picture

List of Theories Evaluated

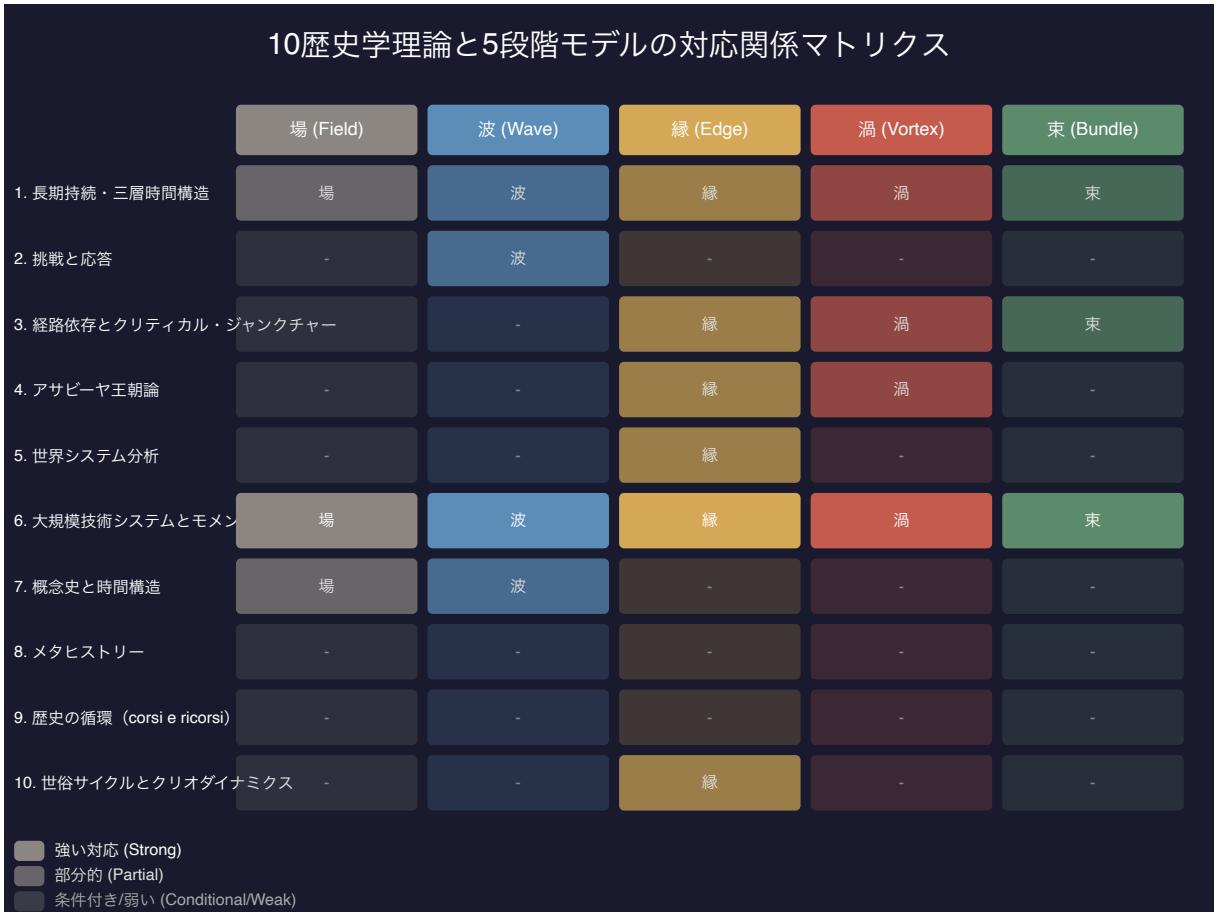

Figure 2: History — ×5

Theory	Proponent	Structural Correspondence
Braudel's three-layer structure of longue duree, conjuncture, and event-history	Braudel (1949)	Strong correspondence
Toynbee's challenge and response	Toynbee (1934-1961)	Strong correspondence
Path dependence and critical juncture	Pierson (2000), Mahoney (2000), North (1990)	Strong correspondence
Ibn Khaldun's dynastic theory of asabiyya, cohesion and erosion	Ibn Khaldun (1377)	Strong correspondence
Wallerstein's world-systems analysis, core, periphery, semi-periphery	Wallerstein (1974)	Strong correspondence
Hughes on large technological systems, LTS, and momentum	Hughes (1983, 1987)	Strong correspondence
Koselleck on conceptual history and time structure, space of experience and horizon of expectation	Koselleck (1979)	Strong correspondence
White's metahistory, narrative structure of historical writing	White (1973)	Conditional correspondence
Vico's cyclical history, corsi e ricorsi	Vico (1725)	Strong correspondence
Turchin's secular cycles and cliodynamics	Turchin (2003, 2006)	Strong correspondence

Of the ten cases, nine showed strong structural correspondence and one showed conditional correspondence. None showed no correspondence at all. As a whole, this domain shows a comparatively high density of correspondence with the five-stage model, though not all theories correspond in the same way. Some draw the conditions of Field in thick detail, while others describe the tension of Edge or the fixation of Bundle with special precision.

What matters most is not the raw rate of correspondence, but which theory describes which stage in which vocabulary. In this domain, body, institution, time, practice, and symbolic order illuminate different moments of the five stages.

5. Results: Examination of Major Theories

5.1 Braudel's Three-Layer Structure of Longue Duree, Conjuncture, and Event-History

Braudel divides historical time into three layers: longue duree, the slow movement of geography, climate, and material civilization; conjuncture, economic and social fluctuation over decades;

and event-history, the short-term layer of political happenings. Longue duree is not motionless history, but structure changing at a very slow rate and forming the background condition for the other two layers.

Longue duree corresponds to Field as the slow-changing structural basis of geography and material civilization. Conjuncture corresponds to Wave and partly to Edge, as the amplification of difference and rearrangement of relations over decades. Event-history corresponds to Vortex and Bundle, as short-term nodes of concentration and fixation.

The relation is not simple identity, because Braudel describes layers of different speeds operating simultaneously, whereas the five-stage model describes sequential stages. Reading the two together therefore requires reinterpretation between multilayer simultaneity and staged unfolding.

Braudel is the only entry in D16 that makes the structure of historical time itself its central theme. Where other entries describe historical process, Braudel describes the layered structure of historical temporality. This makes it possible to read Field not only as spatial background, but also as temporal background.

5.2 Toynbee's Challenge and Response

Toynbee argues that civilizations grow through responses to external and internal challenges, and stagnate or collapse when the capacity for response is lost. A creative minority leads the response, while a non-creative majority follows through mimesis.

A diverse social basis corresponds to Field. The emergence of external and internal challenge corresponds to Wave. The organization of response by a creative minority, understood as the formation of relation between responding agents and the wider society, corresponds to Edge. Creative formation of institutions and culture corresponds to Vortex. Stabilization as civilizational order corresponds to Bundle. The optimal severity of challenge is a distinctive condition governing the intensity of Wave.

Toynbee is the clearest entry in D16 in assigning an explicit role to creative agents. The five-stage model describes process, but does not itself specify who carries the process. Toynbee's pattern of creative minority followed by mimetic diffusion provides a structure of agency within the process. At the same time, the criticism of elitism remains legitimate and must be taken seriously.

5.3 Path Dependence and Critical Juncture

Path-dependence theory argues that early choices lock in later institutional trajectories through positive feedback and long persistence. Self-reinforcement occurs through mechanisms such as sunk costs, learning effects, coordination effects, and adaptive expectations.

Coexisting institutional options correspond to Field. Crisis or political upheaval raising selection pressure corresponds to Wave. Competition among actor coalitions and institutional proposals at a critical juncture corresponds to Edge, in one of the clearest mappings in D16. Selection of one path and its later reinforcement through positive feedback corresponds to Vortex. Accumulation of legitimating norms and practical routines into lock-in corresponds to Bundle.

Return from Bundle to Field appears here not as a necessary cycle but as a possible reopening of branching space when institutional crisis breaks apart the old path. For this reason, the theory treats recurrence as a possibility internal to the structure rather than a necessary outcome.

5.4 Ibn Khaldun's Theory of Asabiyya and Dynasty

Ibn Khaldun's central concept is asabiyya, group solidarity. Cohesion strengthens into royal authority, dynasties expand, luxury increases, cohesion erodes, and succession eventually follows.

The cycle unfolds over approximately three to four generations.

A social space in which cohesion is dispersed corresponds to Field. Growing competition as one cohesion seeks dominance corresponds to Wave. Integration of cohesion through subordination, incorporation, or alliance corresponds to Edge. Expansion of dynastic rule, luxury, and institutional self-reinforcement corresponds to Vortex. Erosion of cohesion, dynastic succession, and the residual survival of institutions correspond to Bundle returning toward Field.

This is one of the clearest cyclic theories in the domain, because return from Bundle to Field is built into the theory itself. It is also the only major non-Western historical theory in D16 and gives an early structural account of history that precedes modern Western historiography.

5.5 Wallerstein's World-Systems Analysis

Wallerstein describes the world economy through the structural positions of core, periphery, and semi-periphery. Surplus is transferred toward the core through unequal exchange, and the strength or weakness of state apparatus is tied to position within the system.

A broad space in which large-scale division of labor becomes possible corresponds weakly to Field. The expansion of markets and interstate competition corresponds to Wave. Formation of the relation structure core-periphery-semi-periphery and the institutionalization of unequal exchange correspond to Edge. Reproduction of the world economy, especially through the stabilizing role of the semi-periphery, corresponds to Vortex. Long trends and hegemonic cycles correspond to Bundle.

Wallerstein is the only entry in D16 that makes Edge itself the central concept of the theory in the sense that relation creates structure. The concept of the semi-periphery is especially important because it introduces a mediating layer functioning as a stabilizing device, something not explicitly present in the ordinary five-stage vocabulary.

5.6 Hughes on Large Technological Systems and Momentum

Hughes presents the history of large technological systems in phases such as invention, development, innovation, transfer, and growth, competition, and consolidation. He explicitly notes that these phases can overlap and even move backward. Mature systems do not become fully autonomous; rather, they acquire momentum through the accumulated weight of organizations, people, infrastructure, and sunk costs.

An undifferentiated condition in which technical and institutional elements remain scattered corresponds to Field. Invention, the appearance of radical difference, corresponds to Wave. Development, transfer, and adaptation, the joining of technical and social elements, correspond to Edge. Growth, competition, and integration, the self-amplifying expansion of the system, correspond to Vortex. Momentum, the persistence of infrastructure, organization, regulation, and trained personnel as a durable bundle, corresponds to Bundle.

This is one of the clearest and most natural correspondences in D16. The concept of momentum is already explicit in the primary literature and aligns closely with Bundle. Hughes is also especially useful because he recognizes overlap and reversal between phases, which matches the five-stage model when that model is read non-rigidly rather than as strict linear order.

5.7 Koselleck on Conceptual History and Time Structure

Koselleck's key concepts are space of experience and horizon of expectation. Space of experience is the layered accumulation of past experience in the present. Horizon of expectation is the opening toward future anticipation, hope, and anxiety. The relation between the two constitutes historical time-consciousness. In the modern saddle period, Sattelzeit, space of experience and

horizon of expectation separate from one another, and past experience ceases to function as a reliable guide to the future.

Space of experience corresponds to Field as the accumulated basis of the present. Horizon of expectation provides the condition of Wave, as the direction in which difference can appear. Divergence between experience and expectation, especially in the saddle period, corresponds to Edge as the point of coupling and rupture between old order and new. Transformation in the meaning of concepts corresponds to Vortex. Stabilization of a transformed conceptual order corresponds to Bundle.

Koselleck is the only entry in D16 that treats historical time-consciousness itself as its subject. This gives a meta-level historical theory and offers one of the most precise descriptions of the passage from Field to Wave, namely the widening gap between experience and expectation.

5.8 White's Metahistory

White argues that historical writing is structured through tropes such as metaphor, metonymy, synecdoche, and irony, and that historical representation is unavoidably shaped through acts of plot construction and poetic ordering.

An unorganized mass of historical facts corresponds only weakly to Field. Selection and organization through trope correspond only weakly to Wave. Plotting, the joining of facts and narrative structure, corresponds moderately to Edge. Establishment of internal coherence within the narrative corresponds weakly to Vortex. Completion as historical text corresponds weakly to Bundle.

The correspondence here is weaker overall because White is not describing the process of history itself, but the structure of historical narration. This makes White the clearest example in D16 of the distinction between genesis of understanding and genesis of being.

5.9 Vico's Cyclical History, Corsi e Ricorsi

Vico argues that history moves through the ages of gods, heroes, and humans, before returning through ricorso toward barbarism. The verum-factum principle, the true is precisely what is made, means that human beings can know history because they themselves have made it.

Chaos or barbarism corresponds to Field. The age of gods, with order emerging through awe and imagination, corresponds to Wave. The age of heroes, in which relations of domination and subordination are formed, corresponds to Edge. The age of humans, in which reason and law unfold and reinforce themselves, corresponds to Vortex. Maturity and corruption of civilization, followed by ricorso, correspond to Bundle returning toward Field.

Vico is the oldest historical theory in D16 and one of the clearest cyclic accounts in the entire domain. His ricorso is not a return to an identical starting point, but a spiral return in which traces of previous cycles remain and condition the next.

5.10 Turchin's Secular Cycles and Cliodynamics

Turchin models agrarian empires as moving through secular cycles of roughly two to three centuries, with phases of growth, stagnation, crisis, collapse, and reorganization. Elite overproduction is treated as a main cause of instability: when the number of elites exceeds the number of available positions, competition intensifies and social cohesion weakens.

A condition in which population remains below available resources corresponds to Field. Population growth and rising social pressure correspond to Wave. Elite overproduction, intensified

competition for limited positions, corresponds to Edge as a concrete branching mechanism. Political instability, civil war, and collapse correspond to Vortex, though in this case as destructive Vortex. Population decline and reorganization into a new equilibrium correspond to Bundle returning toward Field.

Turchin is the only entry in D16 that attempts mathematical modeling of historical patterns. It can be read as a quantitative reformulation of Ibn Khaldun's more qualitative theory, and elite overproduction provides a particularly concrete mechanism for Edge.

6. Cross-Domain Patterns

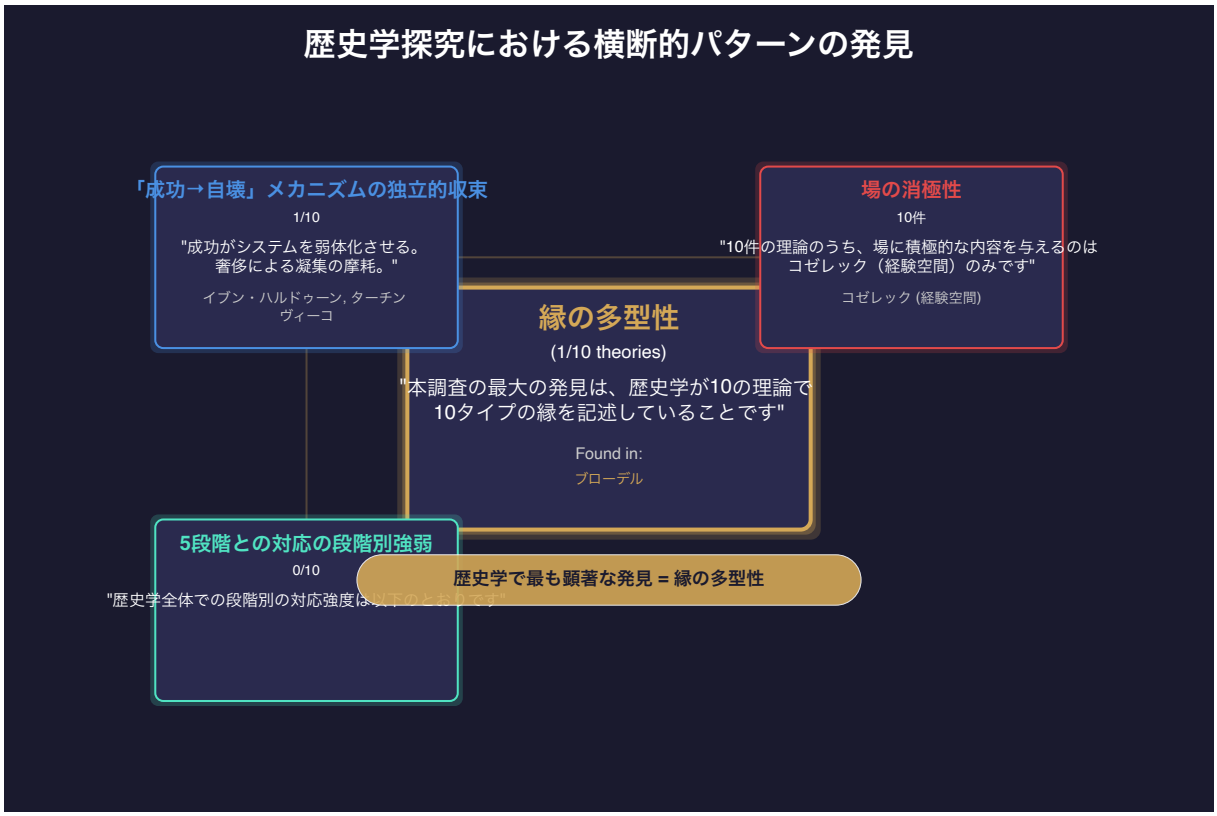

Figure 3: History —

First, Braudel, Toynbee, and path dependence all show that difference and conflict in this domain are not merely obstacles, but conditions under which new order can emerge. This means that the transition from Edge to Vortex can be observed in particularly rich form in historical theory.

Second, Ibn Khaldun, Wallerstein, and Hughes all show that generation is not a single event. It includes the formation of preconditions, the amplification of tension, local ordering, stabilization, and later reconfiguration. This confirms that the five-stage model must be read not as a static classification table but as temporal movement.

At the same time, White's metahistory shows that correspondence with the five stages does not arise automatically. Similarity in number of stages or in vocabulary is not enough. One must ask which concept actually functions as the point of transition, and at what level structure is rising.

7. Unresolved Questions

1. How far can White's metahistory be read as a genuine five-stage account rather than only a loose analogue of staged structure?

2. How far can the structures confirmed in this domain be extended from explanation of particular cases toward a more general model of generation without losing the specificity of the object?
3. Should the five stages be read as linear progression, or as circulation including multiple temporal layers and repetition? The degree to which theories explicitly mark return from Bundle to the next Field differs considerably.
4. What becomes visible, and what is lost, when the domain's own vocabulary is translated into the general vocabulary of the five stages? The boundary between translatability and untranslatability is itself a major question for future comparative investigation.

8. Conclusion

In this re-examination of the domain, nine of the ten theories showed strong structural correspondence and one showed conditional correspondence. Braudel's layered history, Toynbee's challenge and response, and path dependence with critical juncture stand out especially as core evidence, because they describe with particular density either the movement from Field to Edge or the transition from Edge to Vortex.

At the same time, the findings do not imply that exactly the same five stages appear in every theory without modification. The stages that stand out most strongly differ from one theory to another, and in some cases stage mapping still requires explicit reservation. What therefore matters is not simply the high rate of correspondence, but continuing comparison of which moment is being described in which vocabulary.

In that sense, this domain does not only support the five-stage model in one direction. It also places conditions on how the model itself should be read. The coexistence of thickly corresponding theories and theories requiring caution is itself part of the value of the historical comparison.